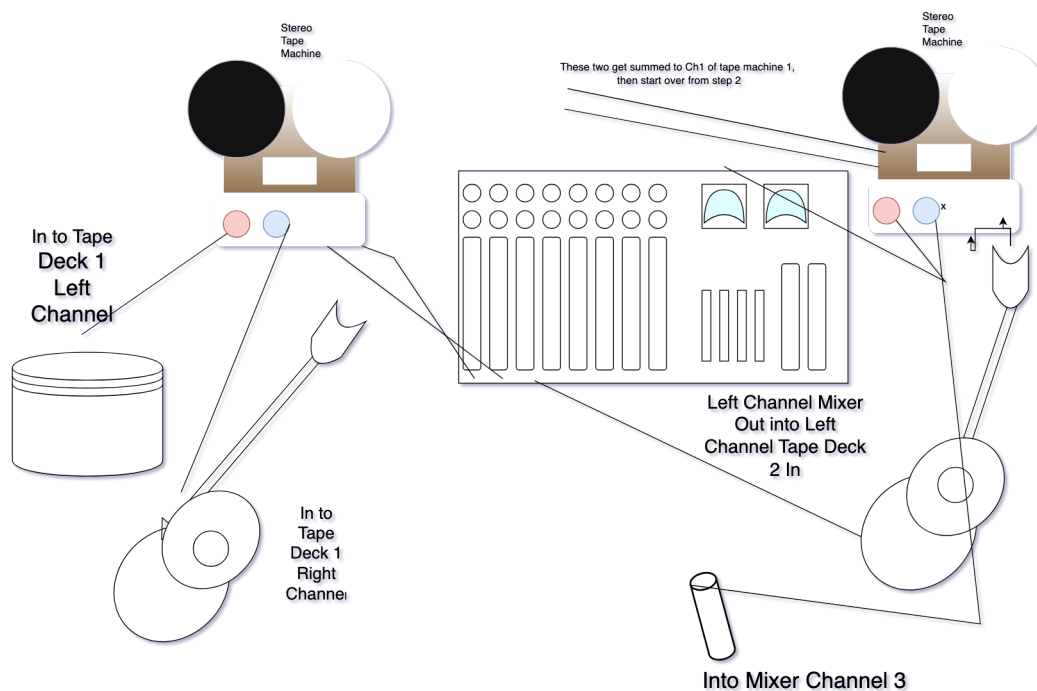




Step 1

The left and right channels of both stereo reel to reels will be used as Ch1 and Ch2.

First record an instrument (lets say Drums) onto ch 1 of reel to reel 1.

you can even mic a whole kit, get a good mix, and use a 4 or more channel mixer to submix your mics to a mono bus, which will send ur mixer channels to a single output, which you will connect to channel 1 of tape machine 1

Step 2

Record a second instrument (lets say Guitar) onto ch. 2 of reel to tape machine 1. you can record straight into channel 2 via a preamp, connect a mic to the ch 2 preamp and mic ur guitar amp, or use a similar/the same method discussed in step one.

Step 3

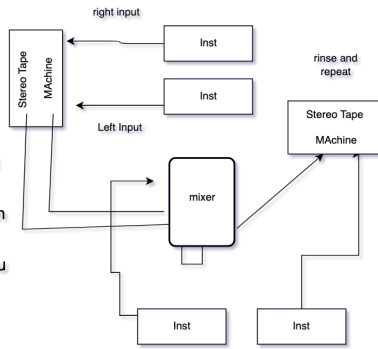
Now reel to reel 1 is filled up! whatever can we do? well, check this out, you fool. take the two outputs from reel to reel 1 (probably labeled left and right but you can think of them as ch 1 and 2) and send them to their corresponding channels on ur mixer. now pick your third instrument (lets say bass) and plug that into channel 3 of the mixer. Now, really focus on getting a mix you like in mono between the two tape machine channels and the level of your bass. when you think you are ready, make sure the 3 mixer channels area all assigned to the same bus, then plug the bus out put into the Ch 1 (or Left) input of the second stereo tape machine. hit record and monitor either using the mixer or the headphones on the reel to reel. play your bass along with the two pre recorded tracks through to the end of the song.

Step 4

to recap, we now have a 3 track instrumental, hopefully mixed to our liking, on channel one of our second tape machine. channel 2 is still wide open! go ahead and record vocals onto channel 2 of tape machine 2. monitor using the headphones, and in stereo mode you should hear what you are recording, your vocals, and the instrumentals, which are locked in mix wise, in either ear. you can do multiple takes until you get the vocals right.

Step 5

This can be the last step, or you can rewind, record over any tape that wasn't used for that last track and keep pin-ponging from reel to reel like this indefinitely. The only thing to look out for is generation loss, the idea that the more times an analogue signal is recorded from one place to another, the signal to noise ratio leans more and more in the undesirable direction, resulting in a quieter signal and louder noise floor. If you plan on more than 4 tracks, tweak around and make sure to really pin those levels of the earlier tracks. If you come from DAW land, red is a fine color when your checking levels in tape world. So crank em, track one and two, so they pretty much pin the needle all the way right (this will also result in some tape compression and saturation that all those plug ins are always "recreating".)



So crawl back to step 1 until you have all the tracks your precious heart desires but don't come running to me when things get messy, that's just par for the course baby, par for the course.

For those of you satisfied with 4 tracks. (or if you use the technique from step 3 here, 5 tracks), or are finally arriving at this paragraph after tracking every instrument in your studio, exhausted, tired, and completely unable to change any mixing or playing mistakes, here is the final step.

What you'll need
2 stereo tape machines, whether reel to reel or cassette. The type you find in someone's stereo set up. This won't work with the little cassette walkman type tape machines, or the slimline ones with built-in speakers (but don't worry, there's a technique if you only have that type).
A least 4 cables, you could prolly get away with them all being quarter inch.
some instruments and/or a microphone as broadly as you want to define that.
at least two cassettes or 1/4inch reels
some headphones.

Since you don't want the vocal only in the right speaker (which, wherever you came from if your song has vocals I'd recommend doing them last, just don't go nuts on the volume or you'll take over the whole song) and the instruments in the left, we are gonna do one more mix down back to a clean tape on reel to reel 1. Plug the two outputs into your mixer on their matching channels. This is a great time to glue the instrumental together a bit, anyway you like. I would maybe use the two sends on the mixer to add a touch of digital reverb (Yamaha R1000 for me) and the other send to maybe a bbd chorus like the 3rd dimension, to give a little space. Effect the vocals however you want. Now pan everything down the middle (hopefully that stereo chorus widens the instrumentals a bit). Connect the output of the mixer to the inputs of reel to reel 1, and here you can make a little master chain if you'd like. Maybe a vca compressor and a stereo eq, or an exciter, or anything you want on everything. Rewind both tapes, hit play on reel to reel 2 then record on reel to reel 1, and sit back monitor the input of reel to reel 1, making sure you didn't overdo it with the effects and that everything sounds a-okay.

You just made a song by yourself without a multitrack! (or having to degrade yourself by creating one of those one man band geet ups the guy has in marry poppins)